

It Takes a Village

A Haryana-cadre IAS officer of Maharashtrian origin inspires the people of a district known for their miserly ways to rebuild a flood-ravaged Bihar village

Punjab
Uttar Pradesh

HARYANA

SONEPAT Delhi

KRISHNA MURARI KISHAN



JOSHI WITH VILLAGERS
IN THE NEW MUSERI

| By Sandeep Unnithan |

There's an old folktale about the legendary tight-fistedness of residents in Sonapat, a district in Haryana just north of Delhi. They say even the mythical Shravan Kumar, in an unexplained burst of avarice, demanded money from his blind parents while travelling through the district. Then, last year, moved by the plight of the devastation wrought by the Kosi river in northern Bihar, Ajit Joshi, the district collector of Sonapat, put a spin on this old tale to get the people of his district to open their hearts and wallets. "We wanted to do something no district had done before: rebuild a village in another state," says Joshi.

The 2003 batch IAS officer who hails from Maharashtra requested people to contribute the equivalent of one day's lunch money towards the cause. Joshi had already got his batchmates in Bihar to identify a suitable village: Museri, with 223 households which were swept away when the Kosi changed its course last year. Populated by the extreme backward community of Musahars, or rat-eaters, who worked as farm labourers,

the entire village of nearly 1,000 people was looking at a bleak future from the high ground of a transit camp. Back home, Joshi raised Rs 1.40 crore in donations. Government servants donated a day's salary and school-children gave away a day's lunch money. The district authorities set about identifying a new design for Museri to fit in with the cultural sensibilities of northern Bihar.

In October last year, work began on a cluster of long barrack-like brick structures with a solid foundation and cement roof, each with 10 single rooms for a family and a long verandah. The project was completed in January and the homes, costing Rs 60,000 each, were handed over to their new residents. And they were pleasantly surprised to see new features of their brand-new village—a 1.25-km permanent road connecting them to the Patna-Saharsa highway, two new community centres, one of which now functions as the village's first school, 15 toilets, 14 handpumps, two temples and six solar lights. Sonapat evidently has done enough and more than its bit towards removing an ancient blemish. ■